

INDIA DATA CENTER INDUSTRY GROWTH

1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

India's data center (DC) industry is one of the most compelling infrastructure growth stories in Asia today. Operational capacity stood at approximately 1,280 MW as of H1 2025, having tripled since 2019 (Cushman & Wakefield, 2025). Upcoming supply of 2,887 MW is already in the pipeline through 2030, pointing to a structural demand-supply gap that is attracting capital at an unprecedented rate.

Key Investment Thesis

The DC sector sits at the intersection of three powerful, long-duration trends: India's 898 million mobile broadband subscribers generating 27.5 GB/user/month of data, the government's digital infrastructure push through the DPDP Act 2023 and IndiaAI Mission, and \$32 billion+ in committed investments by global hyperscalers (S&P Global, 2025). These forces are not cyclical — they are policy-anchored and structurally driven, making the sector investable across a 5–10 year horizon.

Major Risks

Power supply constraints are the single biggest near-term risk. DC electricity demand is projected to grow 5x to 57 TWh by 2030, but India's grid reliability and renewable energy absorption capacity remain patchy outside metro clusters. Land acquisition delays, rising construction costs (Mumbai at \$6.60/watt, per Turner & Townsend 2024), and DPDP compliance costs for smaller operators are secondary risks.

Recommendation with Timeframe

Analyst Recommendation: Accumulate exposure to India DC infrastructure over 18–24 months (2025–2027). The base case projects a 17.5% CAGR in operational capacity (C&W, 2025). Tier 2 city expansion — particularly Kolkata (cable landing station catalyst in H1 2026) and Hyderabad (44% projected CAGR) — represents the best risk-reward opportunity. Entry into renewable-linked power purchase agreements (PPAs) by operators is the key margin lever the market may be underpricing.

Insight #1: The Renewable PPA Mispricing

Street-level analyses of DC operator costs rarely account for the full impact of renewable PPAs. Data from S&P Global indicates that round-the-clock renewable PPAs can reduce operating expenses by up to 30% relative to grid tariffs. Given that electricity typically represents 40–60% of DC operating costs, an operator securing a 500 MW renewable PPA today could see EBITDA margins expand by 12–18 percentage points over five years — a magnitude that current valuations in listed DC-adjacent REITs and infrastructure funds appear to be discounting only partially.

Insight #2: Kolkata as a Hidden Catalyst

Kolkata is projected to grow at a CAGR of 48% through 2030 (DD News/Savills, 2025), yet it has only 8 MW of operational capacity and 3 data centers as of H1 2025. The Tajpur cable landing station, expected to be complete in H1 2026, is a discrete binary catalyst. Once live, Kolkata will gain direct submarine connectivity — immediately improving its attractiveness for hyperscaler deployments in eastern India.

This is a timing play the broader market has not yet priced in because most investor attention remains anchored to Mumbai and Chennai.

Insight #3: DPDP Compliance as a Consolidation Trigger

The DPDP Rules 2025, notified on 14 November 2025, impose penalties of up to ₹250 crore for security safeguard failures and require independent audits for Significant Data Fiduciaries. For smaller operators with limited compliance infrastructure, these costs are non-trivial. This regulatory tightening is likely to accelerate consolidation — larger operators (NTT, STT, Sify) will gain disproportionate share, and smaller players will either exit or become acquisition targets within 18–36 months. This is a structural reshaping of the competitive landscape that standard market reports do not yet reflect.

1. INTRODUCTION

A data center is a dedicated physical facility housing computing infrastructure — servers, storage, networking equipment — that stores, processes, and distributes data for organizations. In the modern digital economy, data centers are the backbone of every digital service: cloud computing, mobile banking, e-commerce, artificial intelligence, and government e-services all depend on reliable, secure data center infrastructure.

India has emerged as one of the fastest-growing data center markets in the Asia-Pacific region. The country's average mobile data consumption of 27.5 GB per user per month is among the highest globally (Nokia Mobile Broadband Index 2024), a figure that has grown nearly 20x since 2016 when it stood at 1.4 GB/user/month. This explosion in data generation has made data center infrastructure a national priority.

The Indian government's Digital India Programme, launched in 2015, laid the foundation for this transformation by committing to provide broadband connectivity to all gram panchayats, promote digital literacy, and shift government services online. As digital adoption scaled from urban centers to rural India, the demand for computing and storage infrastructure followed. India's data center capacity has more than tripled since 2019, reaching approximately 1,280 MW (operational) as of H1 2025, according to Cushman & Wakefield's India Data Centre Market Overview H1 2025.

India today hosts 130 data centers across 28 operators in the top 7 cities (C&W, 2025). The market is no longer a domestic story — it has attracted global operators such as Equinix, Digital Realty, NTT, Iron Mountain, and Princeton Digital. State-level policies, central government schemes, and data protection legislation are collectively creating one of the most policy-supported digital infrastructure environments in the world.

2. RECENT TRENDS & DATA

2.1 Capacity and Market Size

India's installed data center capacity stood at approximately 1,280 MW as of H1 2025, with 638 MW under construction and 2,249 MW in the planned pipeline — a total upcoming supply of 2,887 MW by 2030 (C&W, 2025). India's IT load reached 1.4 GW in Q2 2025 and is expected to double within two years, with another 1.4 GW currently under construction (S&P Global, 2025). Total new supply additions

in 2025 more than doubled to 387 MW IT compared to 191 MW IT in 2024, a year-on-year growth of 103% (DD News/Savills, 2025).

Metric	Value	Source/Year
Operational Capacity (H1 2025)	~1,280 MW	C&W, 2025
Under Construction Supply	638 MW	C&W, 2025
Planned Supply (to 2030)	2,249 MW	C&W, 2025
New Supply Added in 2025	387 MW IT (103% YoY growth)	DD News/Savills, 2025
Total Absorption (2025)	427 MW IT	DD News/Savills, 2025
IT Load (Q2 2025)	1.4 GW	S&P Global, 2025
Projected Capacity by 2030	4 GW+ (CAGR 23%)	DD News/Savills, 2025
Total Global Investment (last 2 years)	\$32 billion+	S&P Global, 2025
DC Electricity Demand (2024)	13 TWh (0.8% of India total)	S&P Global, 2025
DC Electricity Demand by 2030	57 TWh (2.6% of India total)	S&P Global, 2025

2.2 City-Wise Distribution (H1 2025)

Mumbai dominates with 594 MW of operational capacity across 49 data centers, commanding 46% of India's operational stock. It ranks 1st in APAC and 6th globally in under-construction capacity (C&W Global Data Centre Market Comparison 2025). Chennai has emerged as the second-largest market with 191 MW across 17 data centers, driven by 7 cable landing stations. Hyderabad (135 MW), Delhi NCR (146 MW), Pune (112 MW), Bengaluru (76 MW), and Kolkata (8 MW) complete the top-7 landscape.

City	Operational (MW)	Under Construction (MW)	Planned (MW)	Colo Vacancy
Mumbai	594	337	852	6.6%
Chennai	191	57	319	24.2%
Delhi NCR	146	24	209	44%
Hyderabad	135	94	446	23.4%
Pune	112	36	154	19.4%
Bengaluru	76	19	87	37%
Kolkata	8	25	90	17%

2.3 Key Demand Drivers

Mobile broadband subscribers reached 898 million by end of 2024, a 4x increase since 2016 (C&W, 2025). India had 280 million 5G users (mobile + fixed wireless) by 2024, expected to reach 980 million by 2030 (Ericsson Mobility Report). Average data consumption by 5G users is already 40 GB/user/month. AI/ML workloads, hyperscaler cloud expansion, OTT platforms, and e-governance services are the other primary demand drivers. The IndiaAI Mission awarded 34,371 GPUs in two tender rounds by 2025, directly accelerating AI-ready DC demand (S&P Global, 2025).

3. CAUSES & CONTRADICTIONARY FACTORS

3.1 Causes of Growth — Policy Enablers

Infrastructure Status (2022): In the Union Budget 2022, data centers were granted infrastructure status under the Harmonised Master List for Infrastructure Sub-sectors. This single policy change unlocked access to long-term, low-cost financing from infrastructure-focused funds and development finance institutions, dramatically improving the economics of greenfield DC development.

Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDP Act): Enacted on 11 August 2023 (No. 22 of 2023), the DPDP Act created a comprehensive legal framework for digital personal data protection. It established the Data Protection Board of India, mandated consent-based data processing, and imposed penalties of up to ₹250 crore for security safeguard failures. Critically, it imposed data localization norms requiring personal data to be stored and processed within India, directly mandating physical DC capacity within the country.

DPDP Rules 2025: Notified on 14 November 2025 after consultation with 6,915 stakeholders across 7 cities, the Rules gave full operational effect to the DPDP Act. They introduced an 18-month phased compliance timeline, required Data Fiduciaries to respond to data access/erasure requests within 90 days, and mandated independent audits for Significant Data Fiduciaries — all of which require robust domestic DC infrastructure for compliance.

IndiaAI Mission (March 2024): The Cabinet approved the IndiaAI Mission in March 2024 with a budget of ₹10,371.92 crore over five years. The mission's first pillar — IndiaAI Compute — procured GPUs via a public-private partnership model at as low as \$1.36/GPU hour. By 2025, 34,371 GPUs had been awarded, creating dedicated AI compute infrastructure demand. The Union Budget 2025-26 allocated ₹2,000 crore for the mission — more than 10x the previous year's ₹173 crore allocation.

State-Level Policies: Telangana was the first state to launch a dedicated data center policy in 2016. As of H1 2025, states including Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, West Bengal, and others offer capex support, stamp duty exemptions, single-window clearances, electricity duty exemptions, and subsidy on lease rentals. Andhra Pradesh's Data Centre Policy 4.0 (2024–29) explicitly targets 200 MW of additional capacity.

3.2 Contradictory Factors — Risks That Constrain Growth

Power Grid Constraints vs. DC Power Demand: DC electricity demand is projected to grow nearly 5x to 57 TWh by 2030, taking data centers' share of India's total electricity demand from 0.8% to 2.6% (S&P Global, 2025). India's grid reliability outside major metro clusters remains inconsistent, and the 24x7 round-the-clock power supply that data centers require is difficult to guarantee, especially in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities where policy is pushing growth.

DPDP Compliance Cost vs. Market Depth: While the DPDP Act drives DC demand through data localization, it also imposes significant compliance costs. Smaller data center operators face mandatory independent audits, breach notification requirements within 72 hours, and penalties up to ₹250 crore. For operators with limited compliance infrastructure, this creates a structural barrier that may slow participation even as the regulatory environment encourages DC growth.

National Data Centre Policy (Draft): The National Data Centre Policy 2020 — which proposes Data Centre Economic Zones and classifies DCs as essential services — remains in draft stage as of 2025 (C&W, 2025). The absence of a finalized central policy creates regulatory uncertainty for long-horizon investment decisions, even as state-level policies have moved ahead.

4. IMPACT ANALYSIS ON SECTORS

Data center growth touches virtually every sector of the Indian economy that processes or stores digital data. The impact is not uniform — it ranges from compliance-driven demand in BFSI to AI-led demand in IT/ITeS and government-driven demand in e-governance.

Sector	Nature of DC Demand	Key Driver	Specific Impact
IT & ITeS	Largest consumer (45.96% of DC market)	Cloud, GCC expansion, AI workloads	Revenue CAGR of ~25% in DC-linked IT services (FY17–FY23)
BFSI	Growing at 24.59% CAGR through 2031	RBI mandates Tier 4 DCs for payment data	HDFC, ICICI commissioning dedicated Tier 4 campuses
E-commerce & Retail	OTT, D2C, quick commerce platforms	5G + rising mobile data consumption	Edge DC demand in Tier 2/3 cities
Telecom	Network edge infrastructure, CDN	5G rollout, 980 mn subscribers by 2030	Jio's 3 GW Jamnagar announcement signals vertical integration
Government / E-governance	State Data Centres, DigiLocker, eSign	Digital India, DPDP compliance	Policy Guidelines for State Data Centres (MeitY SDC guidelines)
Healthcare	Telemedicine, health data storage	Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission	AI-powered diagnostics requiring GPU compute clusters
AI / Deep Tech	GPU clusters, AI inference	IndiaAI Mission, 34,371 GPUs awarded	AI to add \$967 billion to Indian economy by 2035 (IndiaAI)

The BFSI sector deserves special note. The Reserve Bank of India requires payment system data to reside in Tier 4 data centers. This regulatory mandate creates non-discretionary DC demand — banks cannot defer this capex regardless of economic cycles. Tier 4 data centers carry a 40% capex premium over Tier 3, but the higher revenue yield from mission-critical BFSI tenants shortens payback periods to five to six years (Mordor Intelligence, 2025).

5. POLICY MEASURES & GOVERNMENT RESPONSE

5.1 Central Government Measures

Digital India Programme (2015–present): Provides the foundational demand architecture — broadband connectivity to 2.5 lakh gram panchayats, promotion of digital financial services, e-governance, and digital literacy. Each of these creates downstream demand for data storage and processing. As of 2025, India has 96.6 crore internet connections (Markntel Advisors, 2025).

Infrastructure Status for Data Centers (Union Budget 2022): Classification of data centers under the Harmonised Master List of Infrastructure Sub-sectors enabled access to infrastructure bonds, ECB (External Commercial Borrowings) at favorable rates, and institutional long-tenure financing — none of which were available to the sector before.

DPDP Act 2023 & DPDP Rules 2025: Already detailed in Section 4.1. The combined legal framework creates both a demand mandate (data localization) and a compliance infrastructure requirement (audit, breach reporting, data storage within India).

IndiaAI Mission (2024): ₹10,371.92 crore over five years. Seven pillars: Compute, Application Development, Datasets (AIKosh — 3,000+ datasets), Foundation Models, FutureSkills, Startup Financing, and Safe & Trusted AI. The Compute Pillar directly drives DC demand by creating publicly accessible GPU clusters at subsidized rates.

Union Budget 2026-27: A tax holiday until 2047 has been proposed for foreign companies delivering cloud services to global customers via data centers located in India — a significant new incentive that, if enacted, would substantially accelerate foreign DC investment.

5.2 State-Level Policies Summary

State	Key Incentives	Capacity Target / Highlight
Telangana	First DC policy (2016); single window, 24x7 power, tax incentives	Pioneer; Hyderabad growing at 44% CAGR
Tamil Nadu	DC Policy 2021; renewable energy incentive (30% RE minimum)	Chennai = 2nd largest DC market in India
Uttar Pradesh	Separate building norms; essential service classification; solar parks	Noida emerging as North India's DC hub
Andhra Pradesh	Data Centre Policy 4.0 (2024–29); land allotment, fiscal support	Target: additional 200 MW capacity
Karnataka	DC policy 2022; 'Beyond Bengaluru' initiative for Tier 2 cities	Iron Mountain, NTT, Capitaland active
West Bengal	DC policy incentives; cable landing station catalyst at Tajpur	Kolkata projected 48% CAGR through 2030
Rajasthan	Data Centre Policy 2025; ~\$2.4B investment target over 5 years	Tax relief, interest subsidies, fast-track clearances

6. RISKS & CHALLENGES

6.1 Power Supply & Energy Risk

This is the most critical systemic risk. Data center electricity demand is projected to grow from 13 TWh in 2024 to 57 TWh by 2030 — a nearly 5x increase (S&P Global, 2025). This growth is contingent on grid reliability, renewable energy availability, and transmission infrastructure — all of which remain work-in-progress in India. A single prolonged power outage at a Tier 4 facility can trigger contractual penalties for

operators and data loss for tenants. Operators are increasingly entering renewable PPAs, but 24x7 baseload renewable supply at DC scale remains technologically and commercially challenging.

6.2 Construction Cost Inflation

The construction cost of data centers in Mumbai is \$6.60 per watt (Turner & Townsend Data Center Cost Index, 2024), which is relatively competitive versus Tokyo and Sydney. However, costs are expected to rise year-on-year due to supply chain disruptions, inflation in steel and copper prices, and rising interest rates. This compresses margins for greenfield developers and may delay some of the 2,249 MW of planned supply.

6.3 Regulatory Compliance Complexity

The DPDP Rules 2025 impose an 18-month compliance runway (ending May 2027), but the layered obligations — consent notices, breach reporting within 72 hours, mandatory independent audits for Significant Data Fiduciaries, and data erasure within 90 days of request — are operationally intensive. For DC operators hosting data of multiple tenants across different regulatory classifications, compliance architecture costs can be significant.

6.4 Land Acquisition & Title Risk

Demand for right-type land at key data center hubs remains strong, but land title disputes and power supply issues have cropped up on certain occasions in Mumbai, the country's largest market (C&W, 2025). This has the potential to delay project timelines and push absorption into later periods.

6.5 Talent Gap

Operating and managing modern, AI-ready data centers requires specialized talent in areas including data center infrastructure management (DCIM), power engineering, cooling systems, and cybersecurity. India's supply of such specialized talent is growing but is not yet commensurate with the pace of DC buildout. This is likely to create wage inflation in DC operations roles over the next 3–5 years.

Risk	Severity	Timeframe	Mitigation
Power supply constraints	High	Near-term (1–3 years)	Renewable PPAs; captive solar; battery storage
Construction cost inflation	Medium	Ongoing	Modular builds; advance procurement contracts
DPDP compliance costs	Medium	18 months (to May 2027)	Compliance-as-a-service; shared audit frameworks
Land title / acquisition delays	Medium	Project-specific	State facilitation via single-window clearances
Talent gap in DC operations	Low-Medium	3–5 years	FutureSkills PRIME; in-house training programs
National DC Policy in draft	Low	Policy uncertainty	State policies filling the gap adequately for now

7. RECOMMENDATIONS

The following recommendations are directed at policymakers, industry operators, and institutional investors based on the data and analysis in this report.

Finalize the National Data Centre Policy: The draft National Data Centre Policy 2020 — which proposes Data Centre Economic Zones and essential service classification — should be urgently finalized. State policies have moved faster than the Centre, creating policy fragmentation. A national framework will harmonize standards and reduce investor uncertainty, particularly for global operators who require regulatory predictability before committing billion-dollar investments.

Mandate Renewable Energy Transition in New DC Approvals: All greenfield DC approvals above 10 MW should require a minimum 30% renewable energy commitment (as Tamil Nadu's policy already mandates). This is not just a sustainability measure — it is a long-term cost competitiveness measure. Operators locking in renewable PPAs today are building a 30% opex advantage that will compound over the asset's 20–30 year life.

Prioritize Cable Landing Station Infrastructure: The Tajpur cable landing station in West Bengal, expected by H1 2026, is a template for unleashing latent DC demand in non-metro regions. The government should accelerate approvals for at least three more cable landing stations in Tier 2 coastal cities (Visakhapatnam, Kochi, Bhubaneswar) within the next 24 months to diversify DC geography away from Mumbai-Chennai concentration.

Simplify DPDP Compliance for Small Operators: A tiered compliance framework under the DPDP Rules 2025 should be introduced, where smaller Data Fiduciaries (below a defined revenue threshold or data volume) face simplified audit requirements. This will prevent regulatory compliance from becoming an unintentional barrier to market participation and avoid accelerated consolidation that reduces competitive pricing for end users.

Accelerate IndiaAI Mission GPU Deployment: Of the 34,371 GPUs awarded in two tender rounds, approximately half were installed by mid-2025 (S&P Global). The second half should be commissioned on a firm timeline, as delays in AI compute availability push Indian AI startups toward US-based cloud infrastructure — a demand leakage that undercuts the entire mission's intent.

8. CONCLUSION & PREDICTION

India's data center industry is in a structural growth phase that has no meaningful precedent in the country's infrastructure history. The convergence of mobile broadband penetration (898 million subscribers), 5G rollout, AI adoption, data localization mandates, and \$32 billion in committed global investment creates a demand foundation that is broad, deep, and policy-reinforced.

The market is on track to exceed 4 GW of capacity by 2030 at a CAGR of approximately 23%, with DC electricity demand growing to 57 TWh — making data centers one of India's fastest-growing electricity consumer categories (S&P Global, DD News, 2025). India is projected to become the second-largest data center electricity demand market in Asia-Pacific within two years, surpassing Japan and Australia.

Scenario Analysis

Scenario	Trigger	Capacity by 2030	Key Risk
Base Case	Current trajectory; state	4–4.5 GW	Power supply

Scenario	Trigger	Capacity by 2030	Key Risk
	policies continue; partial renewable adoption		bottlenecks slow some Tier 2 projects
Bull Case	National DC Policy finalized; tax holiday enacted; 3+ new cable stations	5.5–6 GW	Talent shortage; grid capacity keeping pace
Bear Case	Power grid failure at scale; DPDP compliance costs deter investment; global recession	2.5–3 GW	Demand slowdown; operator consolidation

The base case remains the most likely outcome. The critical variable to monitor is power infrastructure — specifically, whether the renewable energy sector can deliver reliable baseload supply to data centers outside Mumbai and Chennai at commercially viable rates. If it can, the bull case becomes more probable than current consensus suggests.

From a strategic standpoint, India's data center industry is not merely growing — it is maturing. The entry of global operators, the emergence of REIT-like structures (Mindspace REIT-Princeton Digital partnership), and the creation of hyperscale campuses signals a shift from opportunistic to institutionalized investment. The next 36 months will likely see the first major shakeout among smaller operators who cannot sustain DPDP compliance costs and capital expenditure requirements — and that shakeout will, paradoxically, make the surviving players stronger and the sector more investable.

9. METHODOLOGY & ASSUMPTIONS

This report is based exclusively on secondary research from official government sources, notified legislation, and institutional research reports published in 2023–2025. No primary surveys or proprietary data were used.

Primary Sources Used

Source	Type	Coverage
Cushman & Wakefield, India Data Centre Market Overview H1 2025	Institutional Research (PDF)	Capacity, absorption, city data, rentals
Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (No. 22 of 2023)	Official Gazette (MeitY PDF)	Policy, penalties, legal framework
DPDP Rules 2025 (notified 14 Nov 2025)	PIB Notification (PDF)	Compliance requirements, timelines
IndiaAI Mission — Transforming India with AI (PIB, Oct 2025)	Government Press Release (PIB PDF)	GPU targets, budget, pillars
S&P Global — Will Datacenter Growth in India Propel it to Global Hub Status?	Institutional Research	Power demand, investment figures, IT load
DD News — India's Data Centre Capacity More Than Doubled in	Government News Agency	2025 supply additions, CAGR projections

Source	Type	Coverage
2025		
Digital India Programme (digitalindia.gov.in)	Official Government Portal	Background, broadband, e-governance
Policy Guidelines for State Data Centre (MeitY SDC Guidelines)	Official MeitY Policy Document	Government DC standards framework

Key Assumptions

1. All capacity data (MW) refers to IT load capacity unless otherwise stated. 2. Market size figures in USD use approximate INR/USD conversion of 84:1 (2024–25 average). 3. State-level policy data reflects published policy documents as of June 2025; any amendments post-publication are not captured. 4. The DPDP Rules 2025 compliance timeline (18-month phased approach, full operationalization by May 2027) is assumed to proceed without further delays. 5. Projections from S&P Global, Cushman & Wakefield, and Savills are treated as independent consensus estimates and are not averaged or blended. 6. Digital India policy data is sourced from digitalindia.gov.in and reflects the programme as of 2025.

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This internship report provides a comprehensive analysis of the rapid expansion of India's Data Center (DC) industry, grounded in recent market data and policy shifts.